

Cover story **CLIMATE CHANGE: PIONEERS**

✓ CHIPPING IN WITH HIS BIT

B.K. SONI recycles one of the fastest growing waste streams in the world—e-waste

Every morning, a van emblazoned with the word Ecoreco drops by the offices of top companies. This is no ordinary van. It is a high-tech electronics shredder on wheels. And it's in demand. Here's how it works. On getting an order, the van goes from one office to another to pick up discarded electronics. While hard disks are destroyed in the van itself, bigger pieces, such as computers, printers and others are taken to Eco Recycling Limited's facility in Andheri, where the e-trash is further shredded and the components are separated by a metal extractor. Workers then manually separate the plastic from the metal. It may be a dirty job, but Chairman B.K. Soni, 50, has no qualms about getting his hands down and dirty. On an average, Ecoreco gets 10 to 15 calls a day. Just over two years old, Ecoreco has processed about 1,200 tonnes of electronic waste as of March, racking up revenues of Rs 5 crore last year. Apart from charging customers for the disposal of electronic waste, recovered metal parts are also sold. This year Ecoreco hopes to close with Rs 15 crore. Not bad for junk.

by Nandini Vaish



^ PEDALLING TO THE NEW AGE

From cycling to preserving heritage trees to dumping garbage the eco-friendly way, PRAMOD SHARMA is a person with an earthly mission

For several years, Sharma, 43, through his organisation Yuvsatta has been promoting bicycles in Chandigarh by way of his "Greentire" programme. A staunch follower of Mahatma Gandhi, he says the "significance of bicycles today can be compared to impact of the spinning wheel of the Mahatma during the freedom struggle". Chandigarh boasts of the highest per capita number of vehicles but Sharma knows it's no achievement to be proud of. With a bank of cycles, Yuvsatta ties up with companies and educational institutions and take them to locations where they can enjoy their cycle ride. With support of the city's Department of Environment, volunteers of Yuvsatta have also compiled a list of more than 200 'heritage trees' in Chandigarh (trees 100 years and older) which are now ready for care and adoption with a mission to preserve them. Yuvsatta has also been involved in promotion of door-to-door garbage collection and vermi-composting.

by Arvind Chhabra



>> GOING WITH THE WIND

TWO BROTHERS change the lives of salt pan workers in Gujarat with their windmills

Their innovation has made the most critical difference to one of the poorest sections of India—the salt pan workers of Gujarat. The drag windmill developed three years ago by brothers Mehtar Hussain and Mushtaque Ahmed, grassroots innovators who own a small car repair shop in a village in Assam, is out to become a major energy saver for the